

Advanced Discourse Devices

C2 · Renan the Teacher — English Language Academy

1. BRIEF EXPLANATION

Discourse devices connect ideas across sentences and paragraphs, guiding the reader through an argument. At C2, these go well beyond "however" and "therefore."

- a) Formal sentence-level connectors
 - - notwithstanding (= despite, often placed after the noun it refers to, or at the start of a clause): The plan, criticism notwithstanding, went ahead. / Notwithstanding the criticism, the plan went ahead.
 - - nevertheless / nonetheless (= despite what was just said): The evidence was weak. Nevertheless, the jury convicted him.
 - - moreover / furthermore (= adding a stronger supporting point): The policy is expensive. Moreover, it has proven ineffective.
 - - on which point / in this connection / to this end (= referring back to something just mentioned, moving the argument forward): The report calls for reform. On which point, several committee members disagreed.
- b) Discourse markers structuring formal writing
 - - that said / that having been said (= acknowledging a point before pivoting)
 - - insofar as (= to the extent that): The plan is sound, insofar as it addresses short-term needs.
 - - by the same token (= applying the same logic to a related point)
 - - conversely (= introducing a contrasting point using parallel logic)
- c) Cohesive devices across paragraphs — devices that create flow at a larger scale:
 - - Resumptive/summative nouns referring back to a previous idea: this trend, such measures, this development, the aforementioned issue.
 - - Signposting phrases that guide the reader through an argument's structure: it is worth noting that, this raises the question of, having established X, it follows that Y.

Register note: notwithstanding, insofar as, and on which point belong to formal academic/legal writing; nevertheless and moreover are common in both formal writing and careful speech.

2. EXAMPLES

- 1. The proposal, controversy notwithstanding, was approved by a narrow margin.
- 2. The results were inconclusive. Nevertheless, the researchers pressed ahead with further trials.
- 3. The scheme is costly. Moreover, it fails to address the root cause of the problem.
- 4. The policy succeeded insofar as it reduced emissions, though it did little to boost the economy.
- 5. That said, not every critic dismissed the plan outright.

- 6. Conversely, smaller firms benefited significantly from the same regulation.
- 7. Such measures, however well-intentioned, often produce unintended consequences.
- 8. This development raises important questions about the future of the industry.
- 9. By the same token, if we accept this argument, we must also accept its implications.
- 10. It is worth noting that the study's sample size was relatively small.

3. COMMON MISTAKES

- 1. Incorrect: Notwithstanding of the criticism, they proceeded.

Correct: Notwithstanding the criticism, they proceeded.

Why: "Notwithstanding" is followed directly by a noun phrase — no preposition ("of") is needed.

- 2. Incorrect: The evidence was weak, nevertheless the jury convicted him.

Correct: The evidence was weak. Nevertheless, the jury convicted him. (or with a semicolon: ...weak; nevertheless, the jury convicted him.)

Why: "Nevertheless" is a discourse adverb, not a coordinating conjunction — it needs a full stop or semicolon before it, and typically a comma after.

- 3. Incorrect: The plan worked insofar it addressed the budget.

Correct: The plan worked insofar as it addressed the budget.

Why: The full connector is "insofar as," never "insofar" alone.

- 4. Incorrect: Moreover of the cost, the plan was poorly timed.

Correct: Moreover, the plan was poorly timed. (as a separate point) — or: In addition to the cost, the plan was poorly timed.

Why: "Moreover" doesn't take an object with "of" — it introduces a new independent point, not a phrase.

- 5. Incorrect: By the same token, however, we should also consider...

Correct: By the same token, we should also consider... (choose one connector; don't stack contrasting ones)

Why: "By the same token" extends the same logic; pairing it with "however" (which signals contrast) sends a contradictory signal.

4. EXERCISES

- A. Gap-fill (notwithstanding, nevertheless, moreover, insofar as, conversely, that said)

- 1. The results were disappointing. ____, the team refused to give up.
- 2. ____ the objections raised, the vote proceeded as planned.
- 3. The measure worked ____ it slowed inflation, but not much further.
- 4. The city center suffers from pollution. ____, air quality has improved in the suburbs.
- 5. The design is elegant. ____, it is also remarkably functional.
- 6. The plan has serious flaws. ____, it remains the best option on the table.
- B. Rewrite / Transformation (combine the two sentences using the connector indicated)
- 1. The theory is elegant. It lacks solid evidence. (use "nevertheless")
- 2. Costs are high. The project is behind schedule. (use "moreover")
- 3. There was strong opposition. The bill passed. (use "notwithstanding," starting the sentence with it)
- 4. The policy reduced unemployment. It only did so in urban areas. (use "insofar as")
- 5. Large firms struggled with the new tax. Small firms actually benefited. (use "conversely")
- C. Error Correction
- 1. Notwithstanding of the delays, the project finished on time.
- 2. The plan is flawed, nevertheless we should still consider it.
- 3. It worked insofar it met the short-term goal.
- 4. Moreover of these issues, there is the question of cost.
- 5. That said however, the results were still impressive.
- 6. By the same token but, we must reconsider the whole approach.
- D. Guided Production
- 1. Write one sentence using "notwithstanding" in formal register about a decision or event.
- 2. Write one sentence using "insofar as" to qualify a claim.
- 3. Write two connected sentences using "Moreover" to add a supporting point to an argument.
- 4. Write one sentence using "that said" to pivot after acknowledging a counterpoint.

5. ANSWER KEY

- A. Gap-fill
- 1. Nevertheless
- 2. Notwithstanding
- 3. insofar as
- 4. Conversely
- 5. Moreover
- 6. That said
- B. Rewrite / Transformation
- 1. The theory is elegant; nevertheless, it lacks solid evidence.
- 2. Costs are high. Moreover, the project is behind schedule.
- 3. Notwithstanding strong opposition, the bill passed.
- 4. The policy reduced unemployment insofar as it did so in urban areas.
- 5. Large firms struggled with the new tax. Conversely, small firms actually benefited.
- C. Error Correction
- 1. Notwithstanding the delays, the project finished on time.
- 2. The plan is flawed; nevertheless, we should still consider it.
- 3. It worked insofar as it met the short-term goal.

- 4. In addition to these issues, there is the question of cost. / Moreover, there is the question of cost.
- 5. That said, the results were still impressive. (remove "however")
- 6. By the same token, we must reconsider the whole approach. (remove "but")
- D. Guided Production (sample answers)
- 1. Notwithstanding the initial backlash, the reform ultimately proved popular with voters.
- 2. The new policy succeeded insofar as it reduced costs, though it did little to improve service quality.
- 3. The current system is outdated. Moreover, it is far more expensive to maintain than any proposed alternative.
- 4. That said, I still think the plan deserves a fair trial before we abandon it entirely.

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